Knock Out (K.O)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25388581.

Rating:
General Audiences

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
catra - Freeform, adora - Freeform, the boxing fic no one asked for, all because one of my best friends did a box au photo shot, it was awesome, so this idea was born, and had to be written, also cause I like to leave box type comments on her works xD, this is me just being a dork xD, it was fub, catradora, rivals to friends

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Knock Out (K.O)

by erzatscarlet

Summary

It all starts and ends with the sound of a bell.

Or

The boxing AU no one asked for.

Notes

So this short AU was inspired by two AWESOME dorks who did a photoshot this last Saturday.
Go check it out on Twitter @Prop_nerd ;D

Chapter 1

This was it. After weeks training and getting ready physical and mentally, this was it. The fight that would shape her future. The fight that would decide the new champion and if she would have the honor to continue holding that title.

She smirks to her reflection in the mirror. Of course she'll have that honor. There is no way she won't. This was her third time defending the title and the two previous fights were no more than a training session. It only ever took her 6 rounds – 7 tops – to finish her opponent. She had already studied the other fighter to the tiniest details after watching her previous fights over and over and over again.

"Theory and practice are as different as day and night, don't get cocky. That's your main flaw," her trainer and best friend would remind her.

She shakes her head and slaps her cheeks. "Wake up! Don't get cocky! Focus. You are not the only one who has trained until passing out. Acting like you did, is disrespectful to your opponent. Be better! Do better! And go kick some ass!"

"Adora, you ready?"

"As ready as I'll ever be."

///

This was it. The moment she has waited for so long. The moment she has dreamed about, so close to her grasp. That belt, that title, the crowd roaring her name, but mostly shutting the mouths of all that ever doubted a small town orphan could amount to this.

For them, the biggest "fuck you".

She knew this fight wouldn't be easy. Not like all her other fights HAD been easy, but this one would be specially taxing on her. Not

every day you get to fight a third time defending champ, after all.

Adora was champ for a reason and Catra was about to find out firsthand what that reason was and take it away.

She was as ready as she would ever be. She had trained so hard every day, watched the videos, analyzed the videos, created strategies, knocked teeth out, and left bleeding sparring partners on her wake for this moment.

She was in no way, backing out.

"You ready, wildcat? It's time."

Catra just stands up, puts the hoodie over her head, and walks out.

///

"Welcome, ladies and gentlemen, to tonight's MAIN EVENT!

It's the 10 rounds fight to decide the new medium weight women's champion of the world! Bright Moon, tell me... ARE. YOU. READY. TO. RUMBLEEEEEE?"

The crowd goes wild. Full stadium. Tickets SOLD OUT in matter of minutes.

"In the Blue corner, the defending champion, she needs no presentation. Our very own Bright Moon star, Adora, the SHEEEEEEEEE - RAAAAAAAAAAA!!!!"

Adora does one flashy combo to stir the crowd and jumps a little facing each tribune with her arms up, waving. Her name booming from every corner of the stadium.

"And in the Red corner, the challenger, she has come from far away climbing steadily in the circuit. The one and only "Wildcat", CAAAAAATRAAAAAAA!!!!"

On contrast, Catra is more sober after being announced. She lowers her hoodie and waves in every direction in greeting. Her name is not repeated over and over like Adora's, but at least no one boos her. She gets a formal applause, though, and maybe a couple stray "good luck". A warm welcome. This crowd knew how to respect a challenger.

The ref goes to the center and calls both women over.

"Remember ladies, I want a fair fight. Careful about blows to the chest and below the belt, I don't want to be giving warnings tonight. When I say break, you will go to your corners and wait for the bell. Greet each other and let's begin!"

Catra and Adora bump fists. To Catra, Adora looks happy, excited, about to jump out of her skin ready to do this. It's a bit unnerving but also contagious. Suddenly, all her nerves evaporate and she is also eager to begin.

To Adora, Catra looked tense, worried, and ready to run mindlessly into the fight. She couldn't have that so she smiled as brightly as she could. It worked. Catra opened her eyes surprised and a few seconds later she was grinning back, eyes bright and ready, and shoulders relaxed and loose.

They separate thinking the same

"This is gonna be fun."

///

Fight start slow. Both measuring each other, trying to find weak spots. Both ignoring the crowd, the camera flashes, and the comments coming from the speakers all around.

One thing is for sure: Adora is tougher than her blonde hair and blue eyes make her look, and she knows it. Catra grins. That's something she can exploit. It takes two rounds and receiving some nasty hits, but she begins her counter on round 3.

“Adora,” Glimmer glares at her. “Just because she is shorter than you doesn’t MEAN YOU CAN LOWER YOUR FUCKING GUARD!”

“You'll have a good bruise tomorrow,” comments Bow while cleaning a brand new cut over right eye. Adora doesn’t mind. She even jokes.

“Pppfffttt you should see the other guy!”

Glimmer and Bow turn to the other corner before looking at Adora again and shouting.

“WE LITERALLY CAN!!!”

///

“That was a very tight scored round, ladies and gentleman, no fighter backs down. For now, score is going into the Champ’s favor. Will she continue taking the lead?

And that's the bell signaling Round 4!

Adora goes on defense, her guard up and perfect. Seems she is listening to her trainer now. She blocks, blocks again, dodge, dodge- AND HER RESPONSE UPPER CUT CONNECTS! CATRA STEPS BACK INTO THE ROPES! ADORA FOLLOWS WITH BODY BLOWS COMBO AND OOOOOOHHHH!!! TO THE FACE!!! CATRA IS IN TROUBLE!!! SHE GOES FOR A HUG, FOLKS!”

The referee separates them. Those seconds work on Catra's favor, who now approaches more carefully. Damn. Adora DOES pack one hell of a punch.

///

“It’s half round 6 now, folks. Catra tries a feint, but Adora reads and blocks. She responds. Catra dodges stepping back. Now onto a blow exchange. Adora lands 5 hits, Catra 4. They both study their rival. I wonder what is going on inside these women’s brains right now! Adora advances and HER FEINT WORKS WHERE

CATRA'S DIDNT! CATRA IS DOWN, LADIES AND GENTS! SHE'S ON THE COUNT! THE FIRST FALL OF THE FIGHT!"

Catra is breathing hard. She looks to the side to Scorpia. She holds 8 fingers up and Catra nods.

"Catra's trainer is telling her to wait the count. Seems they want her to breath. Count gets to 8, Catra is back up- BUT ADORA DOESNT LET HER RECOVER COMPLETELY AND GOES IN LANDING 1, 2, 3 HITS! CATRA IS ON THE ROPES AGAIN! JUST SECONDS FROM THE END OF THE ROUND AND... YES! THAT'S THE BELL! CATRA IS SAVED BY THE BELL ON THIS 6TH ROUND!"

///

"Are you ok, Wildcat? You got hit pretty badly out there," says Scorpia while giving Catra some water for her to rinse her mouth.

"She is already used to my movements. It's like she can predict what I will do."

"Well, they don't call her prodigy for nothing. Hmmm... If you want a chance to go up to 10, you'll have to use THAT," Catra turns to look at Entrapta, eyes wide.

"I don't WANT to use THAT. It's not ready. The foot work is totally unlike to what I do!"

"And that's why THAT will work!" Entrapta insists. "Adora is already used to your style. Changing it now will give you the advantage."

"Or kill me cause I'll be sloppy."

"Yeeeeeeeah... that too. Worth the risk?" Catra sighs and nods.

"It's already round 7. What can I lose?"

///

Not this fight. Catra thinks some rounds later. Definitely not losing this fight. Not yet.

“Who would have seen this coming, folks? Certainly NOT me,” the commentator says to a silent arena. “The Champ is on the count at the end of round 9. The tide of this fight has steadily changed on Catra's favor since round 7. I don’t know what that woman did, but it got Adora by surprise and- SHE IS UP! BY THE COUNT OF 8 SHE-RA IS BACK TO THE FREY!”

The crowd goes wild again. Adora shakes her head and bumps her fists.

This was far from over.

///

“It's round 10, folks. This is it. Last 2 minutes of this fight.

Both fighters with one fall and an 8 count. If it’s not decided here, we'll go to judges’ cards.

And there’s the bell. They both approach with caution. Both fighters look tired, barely able to stand. This will be over soon. Whose strategy will win the title? It seems like...

IT HAPPENED FAST, LADIES AND GENTLEMAN! I HOPE YOU DIDN’T BLINK OR YOU'LL HAVE MISSED IT! CATRA IS DOWN! ADORA MOVED TOO FAST FOR HER, ALL REMAINING ENERGY PACKED BEHIND ONE PUNCH! SHE GOT HER JAW WITH A MORTAL UPPERCUT! THE COUNT CONTINUES AND THE CHALLENGER DOESN’T SEEM TO MOVE! 8! 9! AND ITS 10! ITS OVER! THE WINNER BY KNOCK OUT AND STILL MEDIUM WEIGHT CHAMPION OF THE WORLD, ADORA!”

///

Bright white lights unlike the ones from the arena greet her. She fells softness beneath her instead of the hard ring surface. She fells warmth, but not like the one you get after heavy exercise.

No. Something is definitely different, though not entirely unwelcomed.

“What the fuck?” she slurs, closing her eyes.

“Hey, welcome back Catra,” says a soft voice to her right.

“Who the fuck?” she says this time, eyes still close.

“I was worried,” the voice says. “You weren’t waking up back there and I didn’t want to be the Ivan Drago to your Apolo Creed, you know?” that catches he attention.

“Adora?!” she is wide awake now. She sits up fast, maybe getting a little dizzy in the process. She looks around. Her rival is there by her bedside in her hospital room.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora’s face is as soft as her voice sounds. A tender smile on her lips. Smile that reach her eyes. Catra can’t stand the look. It’s making her insides feel mushy and her face to start to redden. She falls back down on her bed, hands over her face.

“Uuuuggggghhhh I lost, didn’t I?”

“Yeah, by K.O. Can’t say I’m sorry about that. I wanted to keep my title. But you made me sweat and bleed for it like no one had before. For that, I thank you,” that makes Catra lower her hands. She’s never met someone like Adora. Fierce inside the ring, soft and tender outside. She’d never heard of someone so invested in their rival’s wellbeing after a fight. Not like she is complaining. Catra smiles.

“You are weird, you know?” that makes Adora chuckle.

“I’ve been told, yeah.”

“Ok, you’ve seen I’m alive. Anything else?”

“A coffee, maybe? After you recover, of course!” the request surprises her just as much as the pink color on Adora’s cheeks.

“Did you just... asked me out?”

“Maybe, what do you say?”

“I say... that we can start being friends,” she offers her hand to shake together with a small sincere smile. Adora smiles brightly in return.

“I can agree to that.”

END.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

It's a new fight to defend the title.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Once more she was here. Once more she is sitting in front of the mirror with her reflection as her only company in the empty locker room. Once more she was waiting for Glimmer and Bow to appear at the door to let her know everything was ready to begin.

One more time.

One more fight.

One more night she would remember forever no matter the outcome.

She grins at her reflection, excited. These feelings before a fight, she lived for them. These were the moments she felt she was born for.

Adora loved it, all of these.

The tension in her body, the charged atmosphere, the muffled noise from the crowd just outside the door.

She was just… thriving.

"You look ready," says a voice. She could hear the noise from the arena very clearly for a few seconds until the door closed again behind her visitor.

"I better be," she answers, grin still in place. "There are no repeats if I throw a bad punch, no "time out" if I get hit, and no "give me 5" if I get tired. This is it, Catra. No backing out now."

Catra smiles and steps in front of her cradling her face with her hands and making Adora look directly into her eyes. Her smile turns mischievous as she leans in to capture Adora's lips with her own. It only lasts a second.

"For luck," she whispers.

Adora wants to answer, but the door opens once more and Glimmer and Bow come in. Catra lets go of her so quickly Adora feels she might have imagined what had just happened.

"We are ready to g- Catra what in Heaven's name are you doing here?"

"Easy, Sparkles. Just some last minute notes on her opponent that's all," she answers, rolling her eyes and crossing her arms.

"That's so thoughtful of you!" says Bow before Glimmer can scold her as she obviously wants. "But it would be better for you to go to your seat now, Catra. You know only the official team members and family can come in at this time. I don't want you to get in trouble."

"Sure, I'll leave you guys to last preparations then," she says, walking to the door. She turns to Adora one last time and winks "I'll be watching, princess," she says.

Once more Adora wants to answer, but Catra disappears before she can get any words out.

///

"Welcome, ladies and gentlemen, to tonight's MAIN EVENT. It's a 10 rounds fight for the medium weight women's champion of the world title. It's a historical moment we are living here so, one more time, tell me Bright Moon: ARE. YOU. READY. TO. RUMBLEEEEEE?"

The noise is deafening. Over half the people are on their feet. Adora takes a deep breath, closing her eyes, before doing a

couple jumps flexing her knees to warm up. She feels Glimmer and Bow moving behind her getting her corner ready. The presentation continues.

"On the blue corner, the defending champ. This is her fourth time defending the title, a new record on itself. If she wins tonight, she will become the longest time standing champion in the history of the sport," the guy pauses for dramatic effort and to give the crowd the time to process this information. Adora can feels its working. *"So let's welcome her! Bright Moon's superstar, Adora, the SHEEEEEEEE-RAAAAAAAA!"*

The roar is as deafening as she remembers. This time, though, Adora does not show off. She just lets Bow take off her robe while she takes more deeps breaths, now doing little jumps in place, and not taking her eyes off the person wearing blue in front of her.

"And in the red corner, the challenger. This is her second attempt at the world title, her first time being three years ago against former champ, Mara, before Adora took the title from her. We can say she is in now for more than just a title folks, she is in for honor," another dramatic pause. This guy knew what he was doing. *"So let's welcome her, Bright Moon! Presenting Mermista, the SEAAAAAA-RAAAAAAAA!"*

The crowd goes wild again. That was new. Normally Adora's opponents didn't generate that much of a response from the people.

Both of them are called to the center. Adora's entire attention on the woman towering in front of her. Mermista grins at her, Adora is surprised at first but then she frowns. When they bump gloves, Mermista leans is.

"Your tricks won't work, Adora. That belt is mine," she says to her and then walks to her corner, laughing softly.

Adora's frown deepens.

Tricks? TRICKS? Adora never used tricks. She would win using her style and she would show her. She would show all of them.

///

"It's round 3, folks, and I really don't know what's happening here. The challenger is in the ZONE, ladies and gentlemen. I've never seen Adora struggle so much."

"You've taken the words out of my mouth, Rogelio. That's a given! Here we see Mermista given her 110% and it's like Adora is not even giving her 50%. If I were Sea-Ra I would feel insulted, if I'm honest."

"Not only you, Lonnie, the public as well. We all came here for a championship fight, and not this carnage!"

"I wouldn't go so far as to call it that, but it really seems one sided. Adora hasn't been able to land even ONE solid punch this last 3 rounds… Well, there's the bell! Let's see if things change on the next round, 4 of 10, or if we confirm the new medium weight champ."

///

"Adora, what the fuck are you doing?! You are not using ANY of the strategies you trained this whole month!" Glimmer was pissed. Adora couldn't blame her.

"Your eye will be closed soon, Adora. I can slow the swelling but not stop it," Bow tells her. "You need to avoid getting hit on or close to it again if not-"

"I know, Bow, don't worry," she answers softly, feeling a little short of breath.

"Don't worry? DON'T WORRY? You don't get to tell us THAT right now!" Adora closes her eyes and sags. Again, she couldn't get mad at Glimmer's reaction. She feels something buzz against her side and sees Bow take out his phone.

“Adora, you are not acting like yourself! We had a plan! And you are screwing it up on purpose!” Glimmer takes her shoulders and shakes her. “We spent all this time getting you ready to fight an opponent bigger than you, but you are fighting as always. Why?”

“I wanted to see if I could win as I always do, with my own style” she says, weakly.

“You HAVE to be kidding. You HAVE to be FUCKING kidding me, Adora!” Glimmer takes a deep breath. “You know what? Forget it! It’s your life and prestige on the line! Do whatever you want!”

“Glimmer…” Adora doesn’t know what to say. Shame washing all over her. Glimmer was right. She allowed her pride to take over and this was the awful result. It might be too late to fix it. She felt so tired.

“Adora,” Bow calls softly seconds before the bell. “Catra messaged me. Tells me to tell you to stop being an idiot and something about a promise? Makes sense?”

Catra.

Adora laughs bitterly at herself.

She had lost sight of what really mattered.

It was not over. Things were not lost. There were still 7 rounds to go…

The bell rings

… and she had a promise to keep.

///

One month had passed since her third Title match and Adora was back into full training mode. Her day had just began so Bow and her were starting with some warm ups. Routine exercises to get

Adora back in form after the resting period. Something simple like "1, 2, 3, duck", easy.

They had been at it for maybe five minutes when Glimmer storms into the gym with her tablet.

"Adora, a word, please?"

"I'm listening," she answers, not taking her eyes from Bow. "Duck."

"Get down here, now!" her friend says with a little more force.

"In a sec!" Adora replies. "1, 2-"

"Ok fine, I'll talk. What is this of you and Catra dating?"

"-3, du- WHAT? OUCH!"

"OMG ADORA! I'M SORRY!"

"Its fine, Bow. My bad, didn't need my nose anyways," she answers, letting Bow check there was no bleeding. When he deems that everything is alright, Adora steps out the ring. "Ok, Glimmer. You have my full attention now."

Glimmer doesn't say anything. She just hands Adora the tablet so she can read.

"From rivals to lovers?" Adora reads out loud. "Oh look! There are pictures!" she scans the article, huffs, and gives Glimmer the tablet back. "We are not dating, we are just friends."

"That's not what the public thinks," Glimmer crosses her arms. "There are some people in the comment section saying your fight was ridged. That people like you couldn't be so cozy around each other."

"Well, tell those people to watch Rocky!" answers Adora. "Becoming friends with someone you fought with is not a crime,

not unseen, and nowhere it says I can't befriend whoever the fuck I want!"

Glimmer looks at her quizzically. One eyebrow raised.

"How long has this been going on?"

"Around 3 weeks, after Catra recovered from the K.O. We went for coffee."

"How many other times have you two gone out?"

"The one on the article is the third and last, so far."

"So it's just that? Just friends?"

"Yes!"

"But you want it to be more, right?"

"Yes… I mean no!" Adora scowls at a grinning Glimmer. "You tricked me."

"Not like I have to try too hard," she says. "Does Catra know of your intentions?"

"Maybe, but I won't do or say anything until she gives any sign of wanting to try something beyond. For now, just friends," Adora answers. "I can wait. I'm happy with how things are."

Glimmer sighs. "Ok, if you are sure. I just don't want to see you heartbroken."

"Because it would affect my performance?" jokes Adora. Glimmer rolls her eyes.

"Because you are one of my best friends, you idiot" she answers, punching Adora in the arm.

"You call that a punch?"

“Don’t start, Adora,” warns Bow still inside the ring. “You know Glimmer will take you up on that and you won’t train today as you two will go from boxing challenge to boxing challenge.”

“Spoil sport,” they both tell him, Adora sticking her tongue out.

“Yes, yes. I’m the bad one. Now, could you come back in here to train? Unless you want your new girlfriend to kick your ass when she challenges you again.”

“Not my girlfriend, Bow!”

///

Not her girlfriend.

“You received any challenge for the title yet?” Catra asks. “It’s been 4 months. Someone should have shown up by now.”

They were running, early morning work out before each hit their own gym.

“Something should arrive soon,” Adora replies, picking up the pace. “Will I see your name somewhere?”

“Not this time around,” Catra answers, matching her pace with no problem. “We are working in this whole new plan Entrapta came up with. If we challenged now, I wouldn’t be ready,” now Catra goes a bit faster. “And I do need to get a few fights in before they allow me to try and challenge again.”

Adora takes advantage of her larger frame and catches up with her.

“You mind if I go see those fights?”

“I’m sure Sparkles will have it on HD video from different angles minutes after they end but, sure. I guess you can go,” says Catra as they round a corner.

They look at each other then and suddenly both boxers are sprinting down the street.

“Victory!” exclaims Adora as she touches the pole marking the intersection. “I win today, Catra!”

“Only cause I had to avoid a stroller!” Catra complains. “Same time tomorrow?”

“You bet!”

They bump fists and go their separate ways. Adora turns around to see Catra walking away. Wishing her friend to also turn around.

Catra never does.

Not her girlfriend.

///

“I’m sorry, who am I fighting again?”

“Mermista, also known as ‘Sea-Ra’. She fought Mara before you did and lost. Was out of commission for over a year after that,” explains Angella. Adora was called directly to her office when she arrived at the gym. “If I’m honest, she was not my first choice, but the PR team insisted. It would have been a field day for the press if we didn’t. After all, her manager, this weird Sea-Hawk guy, made the challenge public this morning. Couldn’t refuse.”

“Association approved?” asks Glimmer.

“All paper work seems in order,” answers Bow, checking the files sent to them that day. “It is, in fact, approved,” he closes the laptop and looks at Adora. “You ready for this?”

“Yes! I’ll be ready!”

///

“Fuck, I won’t be ready!”

“Yes, you will,” says Bow, passing her a water bottle. “We just need to think of something else.”

“We already lost one month. My style won’t cut it against Mermista. Her reach is longer, her steps are wider, her frame is bigger… I don’t know how to fight that. I’m surprised she is not in the next category. How is she medium weight class?”

“She is in the exact limit of medium weight,” says Glimmer, checking some stats. “It will be a difficult fight Adora, but not impossible. I…” Glimmer sighs. She had swallowed her pride to do what she was about to admit. “I actually had an idea. I already pitched it to my mom and she agreed to it. All procedures had been done and paperwork and non-disclosures signed.”

“What are you talking about?”

“You need to learn from someone experienced in this type of fight were you are in a physical disadvantage,” she says. “I can come up with every training program, methods, models, and what not, but if we don’t have an expert to show you HOW to, we are just following instructions blindly.”

“I still don’t know what you are talking about.”

“Then let me enlighten you, Princess!” says a familiar voice coming from the Gym entrance. “You are learning from me!”

Bow and Glimmer didn’t have a single doubt about Adora’s feelings for Catra after that day.

How she jumped the ropes off the ring to run and hug her. How she took her hands and started spinning around laughing loudly. How her eyes sparkled and her smile shone.

Yeah. Their friend had it bad.

Sadly, they noticed, Catra’s reaction wasn’t on par with hers.

///

“You’ve helped me a lot this past month, Catra. Thank you,” says Adora, one evening, when everyone had already gone home in preparation for the next day. They were alone, left to finish their last work down in peace and quiet.

“Just don’t go and ruin it tomorrow,” she answers. The little smile on her face let’s Adora know she wasn’t serious. At least not entirely. “And don’t think it was completely selfless and altruistic. The deal Entrapta and Scorpia got from your boss had a lot to do with us being here as I’ve-”

“As you’ve already mentioned at least four times,” Adora finishes the thought. “I know. Still, I’m glad,” Adora’s smile is so sincere that Catra needs to turn away from her to hide her blush.

Catra didn’t want to admit it. It wasn’t the correct time or place. She wouldn’t allow herself a moment of weakness with or around Adora. She couldn’t afford to fall for her. Love was not part of the plan.

At least, not yet.

“Anyways, today is the last day,” Catra continues. “As from tomorrow I’ll be training in your satellite Gym a few blocks from here and enjoying every minute of it while you recover,” she looks directly into Adora’s eyes. “And I hope that it’s from a victory and not from a defeat.”

Adora closes her eyes and breathes deeply.

“I’ll do my best.”

“Not enough,” says Catra. “I won’t forgive you of you lose. You can’t lose. Not until I’m the one who defeats you.”

“Catra-”

“Promise me!” Catra takes both of Adora’s hands and holds tight. “Promise me, Adora. You will not be defeated until we fight again. Say it!” Catra can feel Adora also holding tight.

“I promise.”

///

“I promised,” she whispers to herself, guard up, circling around Mermista at the beginning of round four. She was done acting like an idiot. Adora changes her stance and her breathing pattern. Her footwork shifts to something better suited for a rival like Sea-Ra.

“And it’s Round 4, folks. It begins slowly, both fighters measuring each other, waiting for the moment to strike. Mermista has the upper hand of the fight. Adora has on her favor that she hasn’t fallen despite the punishment received since the beginning of this fight. This is not the… wait a minute, Lonnie, did you see that as well?!”

“Indeed, Rogelio. It seems Adora has finally woken up! That was her first combination of the night that really connected. Her first points tonight. And there she goes again! Wow! It seems the She-Ra we know is back!”

“She really is back, Lonnie. After the first combo she went for hits to the lower body. She is fighting close combat, body to body. Mermista’s longer reach has no effect at such short distance! OH! Right in the jaw! Adora steps back! Mermista looks disoriented! And She-Ra goes right back in! Hits to the body! But Mermista answers and ADORA AVOIDS HER COUNTER AND ANSWERS BACK! TO THE FACE! MERMISTA’S MOUTH GUARD FLIES OFF THE RING!”

“That punch packed a lot of power to be able to do that, but it’s also counterproductive for Adora, Rogelio. It uses a lot of stamina, and it’s obvious that Adora is running low.”

“Indeed she is, Lonnie. And Mermista is back to the center, but there’s the bell! Round 4 over!”

“Amazingly Adora has survived and made a comeback! Mermista will be walking a lot more carefully from now on!”

///

Round 7 about to begin.

Adora is has never felt so tired in her life. Glimmer and Bow are worried, she can see it. She knows they are discussing about asking her if she wants them to throw the towel after this round. Of course, she won't let them, but she doesn't blame them and, in fact, values the way they put her wellbeing before any title.

But, to be honest, she is worried herself. Adora knows she won't last beyond this round. She needs to finish this.

It's literally NOW or NEVER.

She knows what she needs to do, so she closes her eyes and focus. She sees herself doing it.

When the bell rings, she is ready.

There's a promise she has to keep.

///

"Round 7, of the Title match. I don't know what- OMG I CAN'T BELIEVE WHAT JUST HAPPENED! IT'S LIKE A MOVIE FINALE LADIES AND GENTLEMAN! ADORA WENT IN ALL OR NOTHING WITH A FAINT AND THEN LANDED SUCH A STRONG HIT ON HER OPPONENT I SWEAR I FELT IT MYSLEF!"

"MERMISTA IS OUT, ROGELIO! SHE IS OUT! I CAN'T SEE HER EVEN MOVE FROM HERE! NOT EVEN THE SLIGHTEST TWITCH! ADORA LANDED A BOMB ON THE SIDE OF HER FACE!"

"IT'S 10! THE COUNT IS OVER! ADORA MADE US SUFFER TONIGHT, BUT SHE KEEPS HER TITLE ONE MORE TIME!"

"And now Mermista's team go into the ring to make sure she is ok. Good news, folks, she is reacting, although it seems they are

calling a stretcher for her. Yes. The medical team on stand-by is taking her away."

"And Adora goes to hug her people waiting at her corner! It seems she's located someone among the crowd and is happily-wait… THE CHAMP HAS FALLEN! I REPEAT, ADORA JUST PASSED OUT!"

///

When she wakes up the first thing she notices is the silence broken only by a constant dripping noise.

The second thing she notices are the dim lights. They have no point of comparison with the lights at the arena. Lights so bright she can feel the heat coming out from them just thinking about them.

The third thing she notices is that she is not alone.

Catra is there.

"History repeats itself, I guess," she says. Her voice sounds tired.

"Well, look who decided to join the world of the living," says Catra, closing the book she'd been reading and sitting on the small infirmary bed next to her. "How are you feeling?"

"Like I was ran over by an 18 wheeler, but you already know that," she answers, changing to a sitting position using the headboard of the bed as support. She exhales, relaxes her face, and finally looks directly at the woman in front of her. She smiles. Catra can't help to smile back, even if it's because Adora looks ridiculous.

"You look terrible," she says, taking one of her hands in hers.

"Thank you," answers Adora. "It's the look of a winner by K.O"

"It's the look of an idiot who dismissed a whole month of training and fought inadequately for 3 rounds," Adora flinches at Catra's

hard tone. “What the fuck was that, Adora?”

“Doesn’t matter,” she answers. “I learned my lesson. I swear that it won’t happen again.”

“I’ll let it pass this time, but only cause you kept your promise at the end and won.”

“Yeah, I won, didn’t I?”

“Yes… you did.”

They fall into an awkward silence after that with Adora staring at Catra while Catra is trying to look everywhere except at Adora.

Catra sighs after a while. Couldn’t keep delaying this.

“We need to talk,” she says.

“Yes, we do,” Adora smiles. “That kiss before the fight, I-”

“It was just for luck,” Catra interrupts. “I told you that.”

“What?” Catra sighs.

“Ok, it maybe was also a little bit of weakness on my part – no, Adora, let me finish,” Adora shuts her mouth. “But it can’t be more than that. I can’t let it. Not between us,” Catra takes another deep breath. “In fact, I waited here to tell you that I won’t be seeing you anymore.”

“What? Why?!”

“I’m set on being your next opponent, Adora. I’m going all in for that title. This that we’ve had so far, it can’t continue. It’s over,” Catra stands up and adds. “We are rivals.”

“And friends!” Adora fights her. “We can also be friends! Rocky and Apollo, they-”

“THIS IS NOT A MOVIE!” Catra shouts. Adora was not making this easy, she knew she wouldn’t. “This is not a script we can play out! We can't be seen all cozy with each other! People will talk! The press will have a field day with us! And… And… APOLLO DIES AT THE END!”

Silence follows for a few seconds before Adora starts laughing.

“That’s your argument?” she says. “Your big final argument is that Apollo Creed dies? If anything, I’ll fight even harder cause you are my friend, Catra. I won’t go all soft on you just because you are important to me. On the contrary, I’ll give my all and then some because you deserve it,” Adora stops, takes a deep breath, and sighs. “But, if you prefer for us not to see each other anymore, I’ll accept that. But only until we fight again.”

Catra smiles softly and nods.

“Until we fight again," she grabs her jacket and goes to the door. "Thank you for understanding, Adora. I’ll see you on the ring, I’ll be the one standing on the red corner.”

And with that she leaves. Adora allows herself to stare at the door long after Catra is gone. She sighs and closes her eyes.

“I’ve waited this long. I can wait some more.”

She lies down again. She had a lot coming her way the next months following this recovery. But she would emerge stronger.

She owed herself that.

Chapter End Notes

> This is what happens when an AU takes over your life... one more chapter to go.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> Welcome! Welcome! Welcome to the fight already being referred to as The Fight of the Century! It will be 10 rounds of carnage between two top game fighters! Adora vs Catra! She-Ra vs Wild Cat! Be sure not to blink today, folks! Every second will count!”
>
> It's rematch time...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She is down.

The floor of the ring getting wet with the sweat dripping from her brow.

1! 2!

She tried to trick her. Took a big risk. Didn’t work. This was the result.

3! 4!

She was down. Was it worth it to beat the count? To get back up and keep going?

One look at her opponent is enough.

Yes. IT IS.

5! 6!

Come on... get up... Get Up... GET UP!!!

"7... 8... AND SHE'S UP BEATING THE COUNT AT 8! SHE RETURNS TO THE FIGHT! THIS TITLE MATCH IS NOT OVER, LADIES AND GENTLEMAN!"

///

"Adora! We are back!"

"Hey guys!" She greets them, steading the heavy bag and taking off her gloves. "That was fast. Is the meeting over already or Angella politely asked you to retire again?" Adora laughs while she side steps to avoid the empty water bottle Glimmer throws at her.

“It only happened once and it was YOUR fault,” she states, taking off her blazer.

“Everything is ready, printed, signed, and sent,” says Bow, ignoring the pair. He was way too used to their banter. “As of today, Catra will be training in our satellite gym as payment for her work as “consultant”.”

“And we are contractually forbidden to approach the building or interact with the employees assigned to her team,” finishes Glimmer, kicking the heavy bag. Both Adora and Bow scowl at her. She ignores them.

“Anyone getting reassigned?”

“It wasn’t needed. The satellite Gym has a well-oiled system of their own. The Director didn’t want to mess with that,” Bow explains.

“They were smart,” says Glimmer, now taking off her fancy shirt and putting on some gloves. Neither Bow nor Adora were surprised that she had a sports bra underneath. “That girl, Entrapta, I would have loved to find her first. She prepared a mock training program to show us how they would be using our facilities and, let me tell you, it was perfectly balanced and designed to not exhaust the athlete or the ones working with them,” she pauses and starts punching the bag. “Now I know how

Catra has come so far. Not only is she talented, she also has one heck of a team."

Adora crosses her arms and grins.

"Did I just heard you praise Catra?"

"I may not like your future girlfriend, Adora, but I'm not blind."

Bow laughs at Adora´s reddening face.

///

"Your stats have improved so much these last two months, Catra!" Entrapta tells her at the end of a training session one afternoon. "Say whatever you want about Bright Moon, but all their equipment has helped more for your development than what our old gym equipment could ever have. I need to make major modifications to your D.A.R.L.A training so it can gives us optimal results for your new physical prowess. Give me 24 hours."

It had been a while since Catra had seen Entrapta so excited about something. She let her friend rant about muscle tension, tendon elasticity, joint range of movements, and other technicalities for a while. She knew it would be impossible to make her shut up anyways. Not like she minded. It made her happy to see her happy.

"She looks like she's having fun," says Scorpia, joining them. "She told you already about the D.A.R.L.A modifications?"

"About my Daily Athletic Routine to gain Leverage and Advantage?" Scorpia rolls her eyes.

"Just call it D.A.R.L.A," Catra chuckles.

"She hasn't explained in detail yet, just told me about major modifications and to give her 24 hours."

“That’s great! I can’t remember the last time you had a day off. Oh! You can make it a cheat day! Like eating lots of pancakes with extra syrup and eggs with beacon at breakfast, and a super huge steak with mashed potatoes and beer for lunch, and finish with four pizzas and more beer for dinner!”

Catra turns green just thinking about that much food. Yep. She was NOT doing that.

“Yeah… no thanks, pass,” she says. Entrapta was still rambling. They let her. “We could do some light training tomorrow. Go running, if it doesn’t rain.”

“Can’t, sorry. Perfuma is coming to town for her father’s birthday tomorrow and I’m going with her. Restaurant reservation. Oh! But we can still add you if you want to come! I don’t think the family would mind. The younger kids are your fans.”

“I think I’m gonna pass on that as well, but thanks,” Scorpia just nods and doesn’t insist.

They turn their attention back to Entrapta and after a quick Q&A they all go home.

///

It was supposed to be her day off. The "sleep late and let your muscles relax for 24 hours" kind of day, but it was the first Sunday in weeks that it wasn’t raining so Catra decided that a light jog wouldn’t kill her. Some light workout. Heaven knew she wasn’t the type of person to stay still. So a few minutes later she is grabbing her phone, keys, water bottle, and earphones and heading out.

Not many people are out this early, so she decides to take the pier route to the beach. It’s been a while since she'd gone that way as it’s normally so congested, but today the hour makes it be void of people. Catra had missed the ocean view. So onto the pier she goes.

About 30 minutes later she is stopped by a couple asking directions. Typical tourist questions she has no problem answering. She bids them goodbye and it’s about to put her earphones back on and continue when she hears it: someone singing a bit out of tune but really loudly close to the mini gym located at the beach.

Curiosity wins and she walks closer. She recognizes the song now, "Eye of the Tiger".

"What are the chances?" Catra thinks, smiling to herself and remembering certain blonde obsessed with the song while going down the access stairs to the beach. She goes down the final steps and into the sand, close enough now to see the early morning workout singer. She freezes and her eyes go wide. Of course, it HAD to be her.

She doesn’t know how long she stays there just staring, but it’s enough for Adora to finish two sets of one arm pull ups. You would think that would be enough, but not for Adora. She drinks some water, stretches, and moves to do one arm pushups. All the while singing that stupid song on repeat, even doing the instrumental parts.

Catra would never admit to being a gay mess, but Adora made it very difficult to hide. Especially when she was wearing those shorts and a crop top. Sweet baby Jesus, it should be a crime to look THAT good.

"You think she is single?"

"Don’t you have a boyfriend?"

“I do, but can you blame me?”

The voices snap Catra back to reality. She looks around her and swears under her breath. Apparently she had stayed there longer than she thought because the beach was starting to get crowded. Of course Adora would gather a crowd even if she didn’t want to and be completely oblivious to the fact. Sure, she could walk to

Adora and save her, but Catra wasn't sure she would resist if Adora asked her to spend the day like old times. A cease fire, if you will. So she takes a deep breath and does the only sensible thing. She forces her legs to move and goes home.

The next morning, she wakes up frustrated and screams into her pillow. OF COURSE she had to dream about Adora in that get up doing unspeakable things to her. Gods, Catra hated her so much right at this moment.

For now she needed a cold shower before hitting the Bright Moon Gym. She could leave all her sexual frustrations on the heavy bag.

///

"It happened," announces Glimmer one afternoon stomping into the Gym.

"Dramatic entrance, as always," laughs Bow. He signals Adora to stop with the speed bag. Not really a problem as Glimmer's entrance had startled her to the point of taking off her headphones.

"Glimmer? What's wrong?" says Adora accepting a water bottle from Bow and taking a few sips. "You look like someone just sucker punched you."

"Someone might as well have," she says and then repeats. "It happened."

Both Bow and Adora look at her with puzzled faces. Glimmer could swear they looked like confused puppies.

"Ok, fine. I'll be direct. You got a public challenge."

"I did?" Adora asks getting serious instantly. She takes a deep breath when Glimmer solemnly nods. "And? Is it who we wanted?"

“More like who YOU wanted, but whatever,” says Glimmer. Bow scowls at her. Glimmer blushes a bit at the call out. “Sorry. Uncalled for,” she clears her throat and looks directly at Adora’s face. Her nervous expression makes her smile. “Yes, it is.”

Adora gasps, hands flying to her mouth. “Really?”

Glimmer nods.

“Right this moment, mom is seeing about all the official challenge acceptance. We still got to wait for an official date and the press conference and interviews, you know, all that circus, but yes, you are fighting Catra for your 5th Title Defense Fight.”

“YES!” Adora fist pumps and starts running around the whole gym jumping around, laughing, and celebrating.

Glimmer and Bow look at her and smile.

///

Press conferences.

She hates them.

She knows how to behave, of course. This is not her first rodeo, so to speak, but its’ not her favorite part about participating in this sport on a professional level.

“Catra, tells us: will things be different this time? Or will She-Ra take the title one more time?”

What kind of question was that?

“Things WILL be different this time,” she answers. “This fight is mine.”

“Excuse me, but that’s difficult to believe after seeing both of you so cozy with one another after that first fight,” the same

correspondent mocks. “I mean, do you really expect us to believe you’ll punch your girlfriend?”

Laughter all around.

Catra clenches her fists so hard her knuckles go white. She was gonna tell that reporter to go fuck a cactus when someone talks first.

“You are a sad little excuse of a reporter, you know?” says Adora with a confident voice. She stares down at the guy who made the question. “Just for the record, not girlfriend, we are friends, though. But of course, you wouldn’t know the difference. Then again, what would I expect from a guy writing for TMZ looking to scrape together some juicy clickbait for their tabloid. How cute. I also love how you can't separate a fighter from their private life, but again I wouldn't expect anything less. Let me ask you a question in turn: would you be asking male fighters this question? I'll answer since it’s rhetorical. You wouldn't, so I won't gratify you with an answer.”

Catra looks at Adora with wide eyes as the reporter in question goes red and starts screaming. Adora never loses her cool even if the man throws many expletives her way. She just stays there, grinning, until two very big security guys escort the offending man out of the room.

“Again, for the record,” Adora adds when the doors close. “Catra may be my friend, but that doesn’t mean I will pull my punches. On the contrary, the fact she is my friend will only make me fight harder and stronger than ever before. I will say this fight will be the fight of the century. Fighting is my life. The day I throw a fight is the day of the Second Coming. If she wins, you can be sure it was because she was the better fighter,” Adora now looks at Catra and smirks. “But I doubt that. Next question.”

The rest of the press conference goes smoothly after that.

Catra still hates them, but doing them with Adora wasn’t so bad.

///

"Welcome! Welcome! Welcome to the fight already being referred to as The Fight of the Century! It will be 10 rounds of carnage between two top game fighters! Adora vs Catra! She-Ra vs Wild Cat! Be sure not to blink today, folks! Every second will count!"

"Ten rounds of carnage? Who writes those things?" asks Adora while Bow helps her with her hand wrappings. "I did say I wouldn't hold back, but isn't that taking it a little too far?"

"They are just selling the fight. Your other hand, please," answers Bow continuing with the task at hand. "Not everyone coming here to see the fight care much about the interviews or what happened during the months previous to the fight. They only care about seeing two people beat the hell out of each other and bet their money on them."

"Well, you got a good point there, I guess."

They stay silent for a couple minutes while Bow checks his work.

"Ok, you are all done here," he smiles at her. "I'll leave now. See about last minute details with Glimmer. We'll come get you when it's time, as always," Bow pats her on the shoulder and turns around.

"Bow," Adora stops him. "The thing after the fight, is it arranged?"

"Yes, win or lose it's ready to go," he goes back to her side. "Stand up, please."

Adora looks at him, a little puzzled, and stands. Bow hugs her with all he has. Adora returns the hug. She realizes she needed it. Bow knew her so well.

"Whatever happens after this fight, Adora, win or lose, this is your decision and yours alone and we are all so proud of you," he steps back, keeping his hands on her shoulders. "First champion to defend the title five times. You are a legend, She-Ra. You have

given your all for this sport and I've enjoyed every second of it. Can't wait to see what else you will achieve."

"Thanks, Bow," says Adora, not holding back the tears. "You always know what to say to cheer me up."

"Whatever my favorite champion needs," he says drying her tears with a handkerchief. "Now I really need to go or Glimmer will come barging in and then the three of us will end up like a crying mess."

"Can't afford that," she laughs.

Bow leaves and she is finally alone. Silence surrounds her. Adora closes her eyes and takes a deep breath.

Her decision was already taken.

No matter what happened today.

This was it. No take backs.

So she starts concentrating for one more fight.

"Just once more, Adora," she tells herself. "Just one more."

///

"Is there a way to find the responsible for the phrase "ten rounds of carnage"? Really, who talks like that?" complains Catra while Scorpia puts everything away after helping her get ready.

"Ignore them, Wild Cat," she says with a chuckle. "It's just marketing strategies."

"Makes us look like savages, that's what it does."

"Then show them the real you," Scorpia ruffles her hair. Catra 'heys' at her and slaps her hands away with a light chuckle. "Show them the real Wild Cat and shut them up."

“No need to say that twice,” Catra says, redoing her ponytail. She opens her mouth to say something else, but doesn’t.

“What is it?” Catra takes a deep breath.

“You think I can do this? Like REALLY do this?”

“Defeat Adora, you mean?”

“Well, that too, but I meant this whole champion thing. If I win-”

“When you win,” corrects Scorpia.

“I rather not jinx it getting ahead of myself,” Catra chuckles. “If I win, things will be so different. You think I’m ready? Am I champion material outside the ring?”

“Yes,” her friend answers. “I do believe that. I wouldn’t let you do any of this if I thought you couldn’t deal with it. And you won’t be alone. Me and Entrapta will be there with you, as always,” Scorpia looks at the time on her phone. “Sorry, Catra, need to run. Entrapta wanted to do a general checkup before the fight. Will come get you when its time.”

Catra sees her leave and turns to look at her reflection.

She could do this.

She trusted Scorpia’s judgment. Not for nothing she was the granddaughter of a former heavy weight champion. Scorpia could have been a champion as well. She had the physique, the strength, the brains, and the talent for it. But her heart was too gentle.

As her trainer though, she was merciless.

Catra knew she wouldn’t be here without her or Entrapta.

She would win this. For herself and for them.

This was it. No take backs.

So she starts concentrating for THE fight.

///

The place is in complete darkness. There are murmurs coming from the sits all around the arena. No one really knowing how this is going to go. Then the cellphone lights start to appear. It actually looks cool, like floating fairy lights in a sea of darkness. Then, one single spot light illuminates the center of the ring and a man with a mic appears. The crowd goes silent. He does a 360° looking at every corner, puts the mic to his mouth, and his voice booms all around.

"Welcome, Bright Moon, to the most awaited event of all times!"

He holds up his hand, asking for silence, even though no one had made a single noise.

"We are going to witness two boxers, two WARRIORS, fighting to be acknowledge as the World Champion," He points to one corner dramatically and a similar single spot light illuminates the area. One of the fighters is there, wearing her signature white silky robe with golden accents, and her name on the back. The hood is drawn low and her head is down. Adora is not standing still though. Doing little jumps not moving from the spot, keeping her arms and shoulders loose, and rotating her head from side to side. If anyone could see her eyes, they would believe they were on fire. "*In the blue corner, the defending Champion. She holds the record of most Title defending fights in the history of the sport, this being her 5th fight. With 4 wins by K.O. PRESENTING, ADORA, THE BRIGHT MOON SUPER STAR, THE ONE AND ONLY SHEEEEEEEE-RAAAAAA!!!"*

The crowd goes wild. They start chanting her name over and over as Adora, with a swift head movement, makes the hoodie fall back. She shows off with a convo and then raises her arms, jumping a little higher, and doing her own 360° as to greet everyone here today. When she finishes, another spot light illuminates the corner in front of her.

There stood her opponent. Clad in her signature red robe with black accents. Her hood was also drawn over her head but she was not looking down. She was looking directly into Adora's eyes.

Also unlike Adora, she was standing still, stance wide, and arms crossed. She looked… Heck, Adora never thought Catra could look so intimidating.

"And in the red corner," the presentation continues. *"The challenger. She is back after almost a year since her first fight against the champ. She already lost once to Adora so she is here not only for the title. She is here for glory. She is here for revenge! PLEASE WELCOME, CATRA, THEEEEEE WIIIIIIIIIILD CAAAAAAAAAAT!!!"*

The crowd response is deafening. Catra's name echoing from every corner of the arena. A stark difference to that first fight that seems like a lifetime ago. Back then she got a polite applause, now she has her own whole section supporting her. People who wholeheartedly want her to win.

Adora's chest swells with pride.

///

"Ok ladies," says the judge to the two fighters at the center of the ring. "I want a clean fight. You both know the rules. Careful about blows to the chest and below the belt, I'm not in the mood to be giving warnings tonight. When I say break, you will go to your corners and wait for the bell. Good luck to you both! Greet each other and let's begin!"

They bump fists locking eyes with each other. Catra notices that this time Adora doesn't smile and just by that she knows this fight will be more difficult than she originally imagined.

A serious Adora was a dangerous Adora.

///

"And here we are, Bright Moon! We have a full house today! Tickets for this fight were so look out for that re sellers made a very good profit on it! Also a lot of problems about fake tickets, but that's another story… Let's go back to what really interests us! We are just seconds away from the Fight of the Century! Both fighters looking pump and ready to exchange blows! Who did you bet on today, Lonnie?"

"No bets for me, Rogelio but only cause I could make up my mind! (Laughter) But it's not surprising that Adora is coming on top as the favorite to win it with a 1.33 (1/3) odds, leaving Catra as the underdog with a 3.5 (5/2). Not too bad if you ask me."

"You think will get a Knock Out tonight?"

"By Adora's standards, there should be, but I wouldn't rule out a win by Points for either of them."

"And that's something that we will know soon as THE BELL SIGNALING THE BEGINNING OF THE FIGHT JUST WENT OFF!"

///

It begins with the sound of the bell.

Adora doesn't waste any time and goes on offense from the get go, trying to surprise Catra. She lands 2 hits, but not as fully as she wanted. Catra's reflexes are faster now. She moves with the punches, lowering their power on impact, and goes to perfect defense blocking and dodging the following 6 blows Adora sends her way.

Element of surprise lost, Adora steps back, also going on defense and assessing her current situation.

She sees the punch coming and blocks. She realizes a fraction of a second too late it was a feint. Catra's fist connects with her side. It feels like her opponent is packing bricks on her gloves instead of flesh and bone. But she is no stranger to this pain. Her instincts guide her and no more blows land on her skin.

She goes to respond.

When the bell rings signaling the end of Round 1 and Adora moves to her corner, she feels a pang of pain and looks down. A bruise is already forming. Damn.

“Adora, are you serious?” Glimmer can’t help to ask when her friend sits down sporting the biggest smile on her face to date.

///

It’s the end of Round 3 and Catra is bleeding.

“I think she broke it, Wild Cat,” Scorpia tells her. “Give your nose a couple rounds and it will get numb. For now just try to ignore it.”

“The plug should help with the bleeding,” says Entrapta, working on her. “You landed some good point as well, though. In my opinion, this round was a tie.”

“As were the first two,” says Catra. “I need to change the tide.”

“Not yet!” Scorpia warns her. “We are just beginning. If you try it now, you lose and you know it. NOT. YET.”

Catra only nods at her as the bell sounds for Round 4.

///

“We are entering Round 5 now, folks. The champion is approaching carefully and kind of favoring her right side, don’t you think so Lonnie?”

“Yes, Rogelio. She’s been guarding her left very carefully since last Round. Catra could take advantage of that.”

“If Adora lets her… WHICH SHE DOES NOT! CATRA FELL FOR THE TRICK! SAME FEINT SHE USED AT THE START OF THE FIGHT TURNED ON HER! She stumbles backwards, one hand on left and

keeping her distance from Adora, but the champion won't leave it just there. She pursues. Catra dodges one, two and OOOOH! Three and four to the face and body! This is some cruel punishment! She is on the corner now, just hanging there with her guard up! She tries to get free, but Adora keeps her there and THERE IT IS! THE BELL! By the miracle of the bell Catra has survived Round 5!"

"And after 4 tied Rounds we can finally say that we have a potential winner in Adora, Rogelio. This Round was all hers."

///

"It's like she has dumbbells inside her gloves," Catra complains, touching her ribs.

"You'll have to modify your defense tactic," says Entrapta. "If she gets you here again the ribs could break."

"In that case," says Catra, standing up. "I'll just have to get her first."

///

"Great job, Adora!" says Glimmer patting her back before she sits down. "That Round and the advantage is yours!"

"For now," Adora replies. "Can't underestimate her. If only I had sent her to the floor. A fall could be the difference between victory and defeat."

Glimmer and Bow exchange looks.

"Then let's go for it," says Bow. "Knock her out, champ."

Adora chuckles darkly. "As if she will just let me."

///

Round 7.

Normally by now Adora already has her opponent's style down. She knows all their moves, quirks, and flaws and goes to finish them.

Not this time.

It's like Catra is changing her style for every round. She feels like she is fighting someone new each time.

She can't read her. Adora can't read her opponent.

And when Catra makes a completely new move going close combat and effectively breaking one of her ribs, is that Adora realizes she is in trouble.

///

"Adora, I'm not a Doctor but-"

"It's broken. I know Bow, I can feel it."

"You are tied again," says Glimmer. "You'll have to knock her out or kill her to win."

"Always with the drama," Adora chuckles and then regrets it. Right, broken rib. "It's not my first rodeo with an injury like this. I can go on. I'll show the world what I'm made off."

///

"Round 5 went to Adora. Round 7 went to Catra. All other Rounds have been clearly tied. I don´t know about you, Lonnie, but this is a fight I won't soon forget."

"I can say the same Rogelio. We've witnessed 8 rounds of the best boxing this sport can offer. I can honestly say that, no matter the outcome, both contenders can be proud of what they have shown us tonight and what they will continue to show us as Round 9 is now starting!"

“It’s a quick exchange, both landing hits, defenses forgotten. This could go to any of them and… OH MY GOD!”

///

She is down.

The floor of the ring getting wet with the sweat dripping from her brow.

1! 2!

She tried to trick her. Took a big risk. Didn’t work. This was the result.

3! 4!

She was down. Was it worth it to beat the count? To get back up and keep going? It’s round 9 already. Was one more round really that worth it?

Adora looks up. Catra, stands in front of her mouthing something.

Get up...

5! 6!

Adora smiles. Yes. It’s worthy. She can finish this. She will finish this.

Come on... get up... Get Up... GET UP!!!

"7... 8... AND SHE'S UP! SHE-RA BEATS THE COUNT AT 8 AND RETURNS TO THE FIGHT! THIS TITLE MATCH IS NOT OVER, LADIES AND GENTLEMAN!"

///

The bell saved her, she knows that.

Her ribs are killing her, and now her most likely broken cheek bone was joining the party.

“One more round,” says Bow, giving her a new mouth guard and applying some glue to the cut on her face to stop the bleeding. “Just one more. Adora, can you do it?”

“If I go, it will be with a BANG.”

The bell rings for the last round.

///

Catra never expected Adora to still have so much energy on reserve.

She was running on fumes and here came Adora like a freight train with extra tanks of fuel.

She got to parry most of the blows by some miracle. It was a battle of wits at this point. Who could stay standing the longest. From the last 2 minutes, 1 had already gone by.

And then it happened. Adora lets out a scream very out of character and it manages to distract her for one full breath. She blinks and suddenly a fist is making contact with the side of her head.

30 seconds left.

She stumbles back into the ropes. She manages to grab on and step forward. Adora comes at her again hitting the other side of her head and sending her back against the ropes. Catra tangles her arm on the top rope to avoid falling as Adora continues with the punishment, obviously trying to win against the clock for a Knock Out or, at the very least, send her down to the count.

20 seconds left.

Catra won’t allow it. She plants her feet firm on the floor, untangles her arm, and strikes back with an uppercut. It’s Adora’s turn to stumble, but She-Ra is fast. The fastest boxer in the circuit. She reacts and fights back.

10 seconds left.

Catra guards from the first punch, but the second connects with her stomach making her slightly bend forward. She was done for. Catra closes her eyes and waits for the following punch to the jaw that will end her…

A bell rings in the distance and the punch never comes.

“AND IT’S OVER! THE FIGHT IS OVER AND THE NEW CHAMP WILL BE DECIDED BY JUDGES CARDS!”

Catra falls to her knees and Adora does as well.

They look up at each other at the same time.

She is pretty sure her smile is as big as Adora’s.

///

She was alone now. Scorpia and Entrapta left to organize the mandatory press conference. Catra sighs. She really didn’t want to, but it was a duty she couldn’t escape from. She was due many public appearances in the following weeks.

The price of becoming the new champion.

“Judge number one scores the fight 9 to 8; judge number two scores the fight 8 to 9; and judge number three score the fight 9 to 8 for the NEW CHAMPION, CATRA, ‘THE WILD-CAAAAAAT’!”

Sweetest words she had ever heard.

Catra takes the belt resting on the bench beside her and holds it with reverence in front of her with both hands.

“Don’t stare too hard, champ, or you’ll burn holes into it.”

Catra’s smile widens when she turns and sees Adora at the door. She waves her in and stands up, stretching. A flaring pain on her side tells her it was a bad idea. Bruised ribs. She sits back down, hand on her side. Adora sits next to her, chuckling softly.

“Tell me about it,” she says, pointing to her own bruised side and swollen face. “You punch harder now, heavier. Felt every single one.”

“We did say we wouldn’t hold back at the pre-fight press conference, didn’t we? And this most likely cracked rib says you kept your word as well.”

“Most satisfying fight of my career, I can assure you, even if I lost,” says Adora. “Second best is our first fight.”

“And the fight when you became champ?”

“Third place,” Adora answers. “I learned a lot from Mara during that fight,” she turns to look at Catra, with a soft smile that reaches her eyes. “I hope you learned something from me as well.”

Catra blushes and averts her gaze. “Yeah… you could say that.”

Adora nods. “Want some more advice?”

“You have more champion wisdom to bestow upon me?”

“Only to take it slow. And that you can refuse interviews and public appearances. Don’t let anyone make you think that you need to be everywhere and talk with anyone. Don’t fall for the “but a decent champion” speech. It’s all bullshit.”

It hurts to laugh. Catra does it anyway.

“Remember that your recovery from today takes priority. If something hurts it’s for a reason, do NOT ignore it. And trust your

team. Heaven knows I wouldn't have survived half the time I did without Bow and Glimmer and everyone else at Bright Moon."

"I know what you mean. Scorpia and Entrapta, they have been there to thick and thin. I don't know what I would do without them."

"Good, it means your head it's where it needs to be. Most champions fall quickly cause the fame gets to their heads and they forget how they began. Think they are unbeatable. People tried to make me believe that. Today proves that I was not."

"You were a great champion, Adora," Catra says, putting an arm around her shoulders. "You leave some very big shoes to fill. I just hope I can measure up."

"You will," says Adora bringing their foreheads together. They close their eyes and stay still for a few heartbeats. Adora breaks the moment. "One more thing," she says, standing up and taking something out from her pocket and offering it to Catra. "I was instructed, long ago, to give this to the next great champion."

Catra looks at Adora's hand, puzzled by her tone. She sees that the blonde is holding out a small golden wing belt buckle. She's pretty sure she has seen Adora wearing it a couple times.

"What's that?"

"A tradition," the blonde says. "When I won the title against Mara she went to see me like I'm seeing you now and gave this little thing to me. As the previous champ gave it to her, and the champion before that, and so forth. Thing is, she told me to give it to the next champ I thought was worthy. Not necessarily the one that defeated me. I find YOU worthy, Catra, so it's yours now."

Catra looks at her with one raised eyebrow and arms crossed over her chest.

"So, if you had lost against Mermista?"

“Then I would have waited until you defeated her to pass it on.”

Catra smiles and takes the belt buckle from the blonde. “That sounds biased.”

“Maybe... but you showed me today this is something you can handle.”

Catra looks up to say "thank you" and her eyes widen when Adora cuts her with a chaste kiss on the lips.

"Now we are even," she whispers against her lips and stands up. "By the way,” she adds, walking to the door, cheeky smile on her face at Catra’s blushed face. “Angella says she wants you and your team at the main Bright Moon building first thing tomorrow morning. Personally, I advise you to go."

And then she steps out, leaving a happy cat behind.

///

8 months later…

“Nervous?”

“As IF! You’ll see, I’ll break your record and finish this in 4 rounds.”

“Now, now champ, don’t get cocky. That’s why you lost the mock fight two weeks ago and made Entrapta remodel D.A.R.L.A from zero.”

Catra looks up at Adora. She looked good in the red and black uniform that everyone in her team wore. Signing with Bright Moon really had its perks.

One week after losing the title, Adora announced she was retiring from active fighting. She felt she had conquered every challenge the sport could give her as an athlete and she wanted to pursue a

different path now that Angella, owner of the Bright Moon brand, had made her an offer she wasn't going to refuse.

So the last 8 months she had been working with Catra's team, helping with her training and physical well-being.

"Remember, you are the one who took down She-Ra. Everyone out there wants your blood. If you don't focus, they will get it."

"Awww, you are worried about me?"

Adora laughs and moves to softly hold Catra's face and bring their foreheads together.

"Yes, yes I am," she answers honestly and moves in to kiss her. Catra kisses her back immediately.

"Jesus Christ! Come on, guys! Can't you leave THAT for after the fight?"

They break at Glimmer's interruption and grin at her. Glimmer just rolls her eyes. She knew what she was signing for when she accepted becoming Catra's new Manager.

Bow, Entrapta, and Scorpia enter behind her.

"It's time?"

"Yes, Wild Cat," says Scorpia. "Ready for one more?"

Catra stands up and puts the hood over her head.

"Bring it!"

"Tell me, Bright Moon! ARE YOU READY TO RUMBLEEEEEEEEEEE?"

End.

Chapter End Notes

And its over. You could say this last chapter FOUGHT ME xD
... yes I like my puns...
Thanks to J_Nerd for the original inspiration for this and for her help going forward. Love you, hun!
Thanks for reading!
See you!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!